

hmuau

SEARCH

To Err is Human...

...to take
advantage of
errors,
profitable!

Nimish Chandiramani

So you've taken your business online. And you've made a pretty decent site of it, too. Now, you want customers. What do you do? Why, make sure that it's on the first page of a Google search, of course! Your probable feeling of déjà vu is forgivable—yes, we did carry an article on Search Engine Optimisation (SEO) not too long ago (November 2005, to be precise), but this isn't it.

Top spot on Google doesn't come easy—you have other businesses to compete with, and if your keywords are the same as those of many other businesses (and admit it—they are), you might not end up on the first page even if you've optimised your site to the hilt. Now what? Well, you could cough up for Google's AdWords or similar services, couldn't you? Or if your wallet pinches, you could just resign yourself to the fact that you're never going to get that coveted search rank.

Perhaps you are one of the Lucky, and your site is in the first few results on a Google page. There is still a chance that you're losing traffic, though. You are, after all, catering to humans, and nobody is safe from that dreaded *faux pas*, the typi... oops... typo. Is it 'receipt' or 'reciept'? The unfortunate truth is, many don't know. So chances are that you are losing a goodish number of your potential customers because they either don't know how to spell what they're looking for, or that they just mucked up while typing on their keyboards (the keys are just so close together!).

True, search engines do come up with a "Did you mean to search for ..." warning, but this isn't always so. Try searching for "kasino", for example.

Can You Take Me Higher?

We don't encourage givers-up here at *Digit*; we'd rather you fight for your customer, even the grammatically challenged ones. The solution to it all is quite simple, really. When you are going through the whole process of SEO, all you have to do is optimise your site for common typos as well. This way, your site will show up in a search even when customers misspell keywords. In fact,

it is more than probable that you'll be higher on the result list!

For example, "Grammar Gorillas" is the top result on a search for "grammer", but fifth on a search for "grammar". Even if you consider the "kasino" example in Google, look to the right and you'll see ads for online Casinos. Now if they could do it for the ads, why can't you do it for your site?

So as part of your SEO, do your research—once you have decided on your search keywords, trawl the net to see which ones are among commonly misspelled words. You could also use tools like the keyword typo generator at www.SEOChat.com or www.keywordsfinder.com to give you a list of possible typos for your keywords.

For example, we typed "keyboard" into the typo generator on www.SEOChat.com, and this is what it came up with:

keyborad ieyboard oeyboard leyboard meyboard ketboard keuboard kehboard keynoard keygoard keyvoard keybiard keyblard keybpard keybosrd

Some of these seem a little silly, but that's because the typo generators don't work with grammar. The typos are based on the closeness of the letters on keyboard—you'd invariably end up typing 'I' when you *really* wanted 'O'. Another common way to end up with a typo is jubmbling up the letters.

Simple, isn't it? Well, no.

Flashback

Before we move ahead, let's take a look at a few SEO tips. First up, choose your keywords well. Something generic like "hardware" will get you nowhere. Try "hardware supplier [your city]" or something like that—a key *phrase*, rather, which will bring your site up on a more specific search. Once you have chosen your keywords, weave at least one—and at most three—of them into your page title. This will be the **TITLE** HTML tag on your page.

Next in line is the Meta tag, which contains the keywords and a short description of your site. In the years B.G. (Before Google), a Meta tag would play a major role in your site ranking on a search, but this has diminished somewhat. Still, you